



A servant sets out a bowl of soup, roasted animal ribs, and flat bread.

A fan is used by the servant to protect the meal from flies.

An Assyrian man is sliding food into or out of an oven.

The oven would have been used to bake bread or roast meat.



The Assyrian Empire

The empire is shown here at its height in 705 BCE, but before the incursions into Egypt. Assyria was for 200 years the principal power in the Middle East, before it was crushed by the Medes and Babylonians.

provinces, and newly conquered kingdoms were incorporated as provinces (with each one usually split up into two or more).

The governors in charge of the provinces were directly appointed by the king. However, instead of governors being drawn from the local dynasty who had ruled before Assyria took over, or from the ruling family, the Assyrian king relied on eunuchs to represent his interests. As the eunuch governors could not have children, there was no danger that they would try to start their own dynasty.

The strong administration kept close control over the regions. It ensured that the provinces raised taxes and sent troops directly to wherever they were needed. At the top of the hierarchy, the king, the ultimate lawgiver, was aided by a powerful aristocracy from whom leading officials and army commanders were drawn. At the bottom, most of

the population were peasants, paying their local lord with goods or services in return for protection. Village life changed little through successive kings.

Managing the empire

Assyrian rule had all the hallmarks of a strong empire: clever control tactics, good communication links, and varied trading connections. The Assyrians shrewdly sought to dominate areas that they had previously conquered in the Middle Assyrian period, which made it appear that they were reasserting their natural rights to those territories.

Parts of the empire were linked with a system of roads. "Royal roads" had stations for the express delivery of state correspondence using dispatch riders. This ambitious road network formed the basis of the later Persian system (see pp.90–91, 92–93). The roads were useful for overland trade, too. Strong trading links were developed with the Phoenician city-state of Tyre (see pp.82–83, 132), and Assyria built an impressive trading network across the Mediterranean as well as connections with the Arabs, and an ancient Iranian people called the Medes.



Tribute from Israel

Jehu, king of Israel, prostrates himself before the 9th-century-BCE Assyrian king Shalmaneser III. The scene is one of several such reliefs on a public monument erected at Nimrud in 825 BCE.

AFTER

"The Assyrian came down like the wolf on the fold, And his cohorts were gleaming in purple and gold."

LORD BYRON, FROM HIS POEM "THE DESTRUCTION OF SENNACHERIB," 1815

The Assyrian Empire, so aggressively built, could not withstand internal division.

KING SENNACHERIB

The Assyrian king Sennacherib (704–681 BCE), based at his spectacular capital, Nineveh, aggressively defended the empire's borders. His campaigns included sacking the city of Lachish in Judah (south of Israel), and crushing



Babylonia by destroying its capital, Babylon—although the city was later rebuilt by Sennacherib's son, Esarhaddon. Babylonia had once been a major Mesopotamian kingdom in the 2nd millennium BCE

<< 55, 78–79 and emerged again from Assyria's shadow at the end of the 7th century BCE. 90, 92 >>.

CONQUEST OF EGYPT

Assyria conquered Egypt << 65 in the 7th century BCE and ended the rule of the Nubian dynasty. They put the native Egyptian Saite

SENNACHERIB'S CAPTURE OF LACHISH

dynasty into power as puppet rulers, but Egypt then regained independence 118–19 >> under the Egyptian pharaoh Psammetichus I (664–610 BCE).

BROTHER WAR

The empire was weakened in 652–648 BCE by a war between Esarhaddon's sons: Shamash-shumu-ukin, whom he had installed as ruler of Babylon, and Assurbanipal, the eventual victor.

BABYLONIANS AND MEDES

On Assurbanipal's death, the empire endured a succession crisis, and when the Babylonians and Medes attacked and captured the city of Ashur in 614 BCE, the empire quickly disintegrated.